‘Now about two hundred people assembled on all sides,’ wrote Mohan Lal, ‘and Sir Alexander Burnes, from the window of his upper room, demanded the insurgents to pacify themselves, and promised a handsome reward to all.’ With him on the balcony was Captain William Broadfoot, the younger brother of General Sale’s red-haired engineer, and Burnes’s own younger brother, Charles, who had just arrived in Kabul.

> While he was haranguing the mob, Captain Broadfoot received a [musket] ball just below his breast, and was brought down by Sir Alexander and his brother Charles and placed in the room downstairs. The [sepoy] guard, being now under sharp fire from the rebels, opposed the advance. Some of the servants of Sir Alexander desired him to permit himself to be wrapped up in a tent, which they would carry off on their shoulders, in the way that many others were carrying off plunder, but he said he could neither leave his own brother, nor his wounded friend Captain Broadfoot.

At this point the mob managed to set fire to the gateway of Burnes’s house, ‘the flames extending to the room where Sir Alexander and his brother were standing, looking at the multitude and begging for quarter. Captain Broadfoot was consumed in it. Lt Charles Burnes then came out into the garden and killed about six persons before he was cut to pieces.’

Mohan Lal was standing on his rooftop, watching on with horror, as musket balls passing on from Burnes’s house pitted the walls and shattered the windows around him. Now he was spotted by the rooftop musketeers and had to make a rapid exit. This he made through a hole in the exterior wall of his compound that he had had specially prepared for his escape. His plan was to make a dash for the well-defended walled Qizilbash quarter of Murad Khani and fetch the pro-British Shia leader, Khan Shirin Khan, to the aid of Burnes. As he was rushing through the streets, however, he was seized by a group of insurgents coming from the opposite direction. They had surrounded him and were about to behead him as a Kafir spy when, by good fortune, the group ran into the elderly Barakzai chief and first cousin of Dost Mohammad, Mohammad Zaman Khan, whose surrender and integration in Shuja’s court Mohan Lal had facilitated a year earlier:

> The Nawab came out of his house and upbraided those who had seized me. Snatching me away from their hands, he took me away and placed me among his ladies, who having received some assistance from me some time before, brought a sumptuous dish of ‘pulav’ for my breakfast. To enjoy this hospitality from the hands of the Afghan fair on other occasions would have been an unexpected and highly valued nourishment, but at the present disastrous moment, every grain of rice seemed to choak in my throat. I was now locked in a dark room and the good Nawab